# ELIMINATION PLAYS

## ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

## ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| ♦ K 10 3 | ♦ J 7 3 | ♦ K 10 3 |
| | | |
| ♦ A J 7 | ♦ Q 5 2 | ♦ A 9 7 |

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

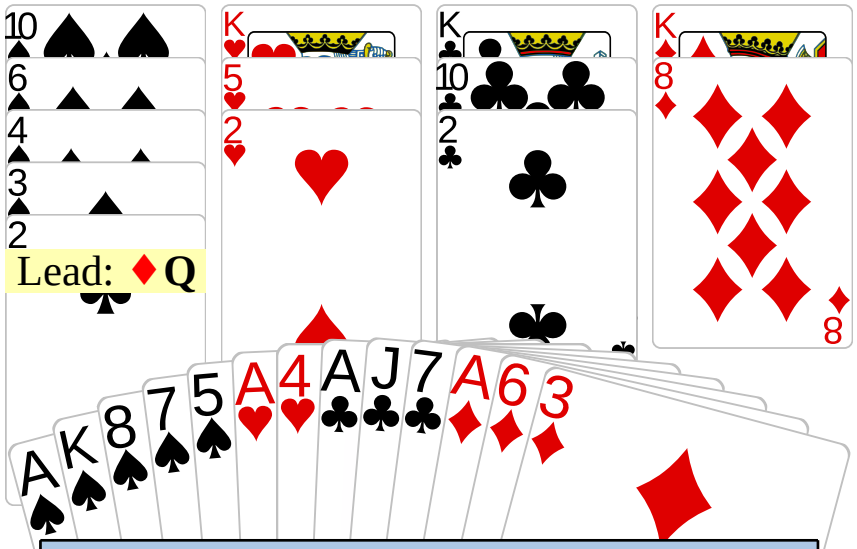
These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

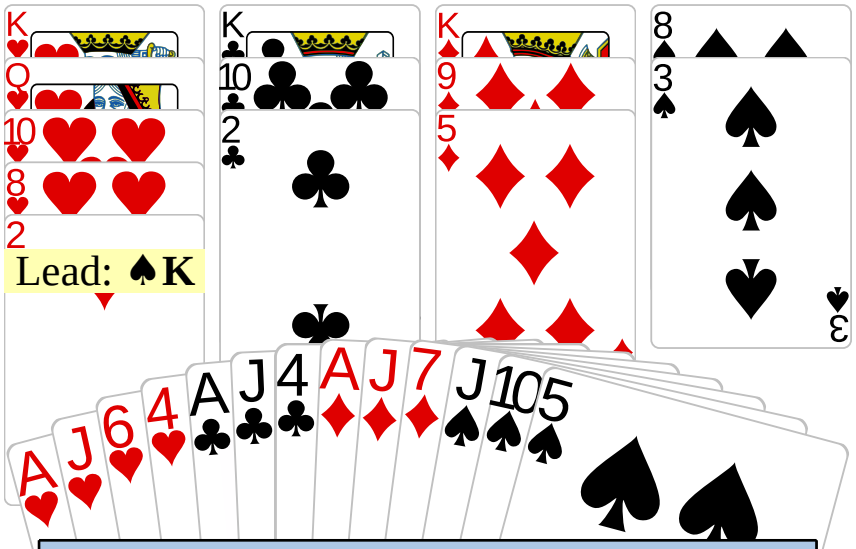
25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

**Deal 1** Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 2** Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



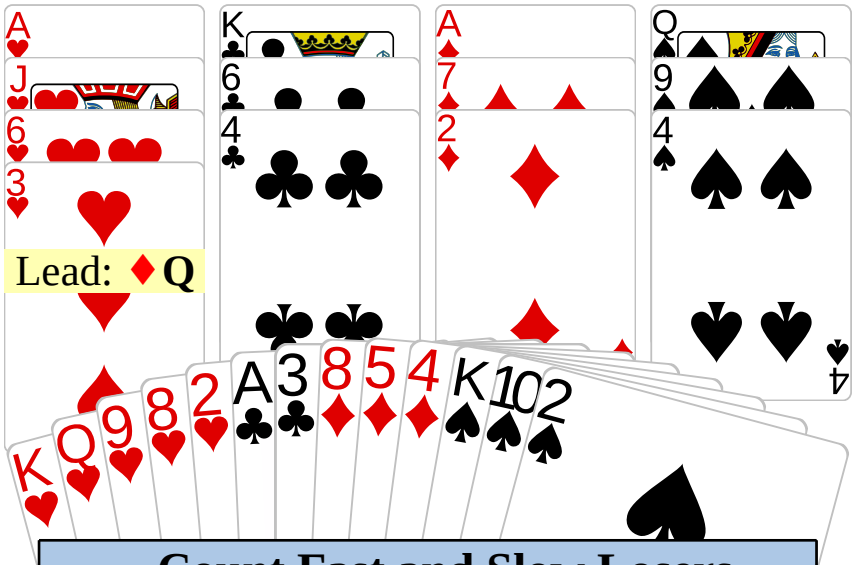

| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 3** Ctr: **6♦** Goal: at most ____ losers



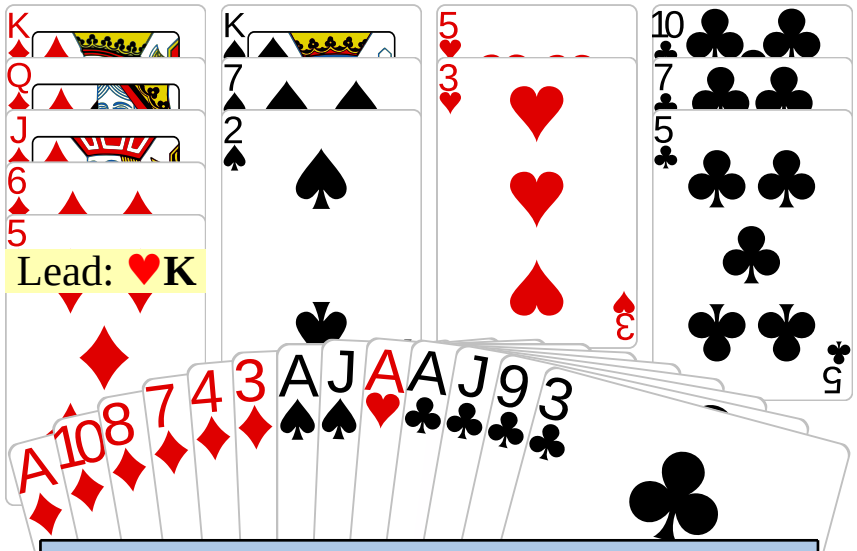

| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 4** Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 5** Ctr: **6♦** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠K

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♦
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♦
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

***Board 1***
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A K 8 7 5
♥ A 4
♦ A 6 3
♣ A J 7

♠ Q J 9
♥ Q 10 7 6
♦ 10 5 2
♣ 9 6 4




♠ —
♥ J 9 8 3
♦ Q J 9 7 4
♣ Q 8 5 3

♠ 10 6 4 3 2
♥ K 5 2
♦ K 8
♣ K 10 2

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♠ | Pass | 3♠ |
| Pass | 6♠ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

6♠ by North
Lead: ♦Q

South decides a limit raise is better than just jumping to game. North has heard enough and bids the slam.

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♦Q.

Your first thought is probably that if you can guess the ♣Q you will make all thirteen tricks.

So you win the ♦K and play a ♠ to your ♠K. When East discards a ♦ your second thought is probably that you **MUST** guess the ♣Q just to make twelve tricks.

Hopefully your third thought is that if you use an elimination play you won't have to guess.

Play your ♠A, leaving West with the master ♠Q. Then eliminate ♦s by playing ♦A and ruffing a ♦ in dummy.

Now eliminate ♥s by playing ♥A, ♥K, and ruffing a ♥.

You are ready for the throw-in.

A ♠ to West's ♠Q.

West has just taken the defender's first trick. First and only. Because if he now plays a red card you will ruff in one hand and discard a losing ♣ from the other. And if he plays a ♣ you will no longer have a ♣ loser.

Most elimination plays work on the same principle. The biggest difference is usually the technique you have to use to complete the eliminations.

Here it took two ruffs, one in each hand.

***Board 2***
East Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A 7 6<br>♥ 9 7 3<br>♦ 10 6 4 3<br>♣ Q 8 7 | |
| ♠ 8 3<br>♥ K Q 10 8 2<br>♦ K 9 5<br>♣ K 10 2 |  | ♠ J 10 5<br>♥ A J 6 4<br>♦ A J 7<br>♣ A J 4 |
| | ♠ K Q 9 4 2<br>♥ 5<br>♦ Q 8 2<br>♣ 9 6 5 3 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1NT | Pass |
| 2♦ | Pass | 2♥ | Pass |
| 3NT | Pass | 4♥ | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by East
Lead: ♠K

West first transfers you to ♥s, then gives you a choice of which game to play. Knowing you have an 9-card trump fit, you choose 4♥.

East is to play 4♥. The defenders start with ♠K, ♠Q, ♠A.

In addition to the two ♠s already lost you have a potential loser in each minor suit. On the plus side, you have a finesse position in ♦s and a two-way finesse in ♣s. If you work both finesses successfully you make an overtrick - if both fail you will be down 1. Or, you could try for a 100% sure end-play.

Ruff the ♠A with dummy's ♥10 and pull trumps (three rounds).

You cash the ♦K and ♦A.

You eliminate ♦s with the ♦K, ♦A and ♦J. If you are REALLY lucky the ♦Q will fall doubleton, but more than likely a defender will win the third ♦. He won't be happy about it, though.

Whichever defender wins the ♦Q is end-played. If he plays a ♦ or a ♠ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♣ loser from the other. But if he leads a ♣ instead you no longer have a ♣ loser.

On this Deal an elimination play will guarantee that you make your contract.

However, it also guarantees that you will not make an overtrick.

If you try the two finesses instead you **MIGHT** make an overtrick, but you also might go down 1.

Decide for yourself!

***Board 3***
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A
♥ A K 6
♦ A K Q 9 7 4
♣ A Q 9

♠ Q J 10 5 3
♥ Q 8 7 2
♦ 3
♣ J 8 5




♠ K 9 7 4
♥ 10 9 5 4
♦ 8 2
♣ K 10 2

♠ 8 6 2
♥ J 3
♦ J 10 6 5
♣ 7 6 4 3

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 2♣ | Pass | 2♦ |
| Pass | 3♦ | Pass | 4♦ |
| Pass | 6♦ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

6♦ by South
Lead: ♠Q

You naturally respond 2♦ to North's strong 2♣ opener. Before you know it you are playing a slam - with your mighty 2-point hand! South plays 6♦. West leads the ♠Q.

If the contract appears to depend upon a finesse, try to find another way. Here, you can always try the ♣ finesse, but maybe you can eliminate ♠s and see what happens.

Win the ♠A, play the ♦4 to the ♦10, and ruff a ♠ with the ♦Q. Both opponents followed to the trump.

Play the ♦7 to the ♦J and ruff the last ♠ with the ♦K.

Having eliminated the ♦s and ♠s, now remove the ♥s. Play ♥A, ♥K, and ruff a ♥.

At last it is time to play ♣s.

West plays low.

A ♣ from your hand, playing dummy's ♣9 when West plays low. East will win the trick but will be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣ A Q, or give you a ruff-sluff.

If West puts on either the ♣10 or ♣J you play dummy's ♣Q. If East can win with the ♣K he will once again be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣A 9, or give you a ruff-sluff.

The A Q 9 combination is interesting. Obviously if you have A Q 10 it works very well in an end-play situation.

As you see, A Q 9 actually works just as well.

***Board 4***
East Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A 8 6 3<br>♥ 7<br>♦ Q J 10 6<br>♣ J 10 7 2 | |
| ♠ K 10 2<br>♥ K Q 9 8 2<br>♦ 8 5 4<br>♣ A 3 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ Q 9 4<br>♥ A J 6 3<br>♦ A 7 2<br>♣ K 6 4 |
| | ♠ J 7 5<br>♥ 10 5 4<br>♦ K 9 3<br>♣ Q 9 8 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1♣ | Pass |
| 1♥ | Pass | 2♥ | Pass |
| 4♥ | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by West
Lead: ♦Q

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♦Q.

You have two ♦ losers that you can't escape, as well as the ♠A. So you must arrange your play so you don't lose a trick to the ♠J. That could mean you will finesse one defender for that card, but it would be a lot better if you could make the defense play ♠s first.

There is no reason to hold up so take your ♦A and pull trumps, South showing up with three of them.

Now eliminate ♣s by playing ♣A, ♣K, and ruffing a ♣.

The stage is now set for the throw-in.

Be **SURE** to lead a ♦ for the throw-in, not a ♠.

The defense will win the ♦ and can then take another ♦ trick if they like. But then they will have to play a ♠ (or give you a ruff-sluff). And as long as they start the ♠s you are assured that you will lose only one ♠ trick, the ♠A.

Assume North is on lead for the first ♠ play.

If he leads the ♠A it sets up both the ♠K and ♠Q so you only have one ♠ loser. If he leads low you also play low from dummy and South must play the ♠J to prevent you getting a trick with the ♠10. Again you only lose one ♠.

If South makes the first play by leading a low ♠ you play low from your hand. North must go up with the ♠A to stop you from getting a trick with dummy's ♠9. Then your ♠K and ♠Q will win two tricks.

***Board 5***
West Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A J<br>♥ A<br>♦ A 10 8 7 4 3<br>♣ A J 9 3 | |
| ♠ Q 9 6 4 3<br>♥ 9 7 6 2<br>♦ 9 2<br>♣ 8 6 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 10 8 5<br>♥ K Q J 10 8 4<br>♦ —<br>♣ K Q 4 2 |
| | ♠ K 7 2<br>♥ 5 3<br>♦ K Q J 6 5<br>♣ 10 7 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pass | 1♦ | 1♥ | 2♥ |
| Dbl | 6♦ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

6♦ by North
Lead: ♥K

South's 2♥ bid showed a hand with limit raise or better in ♦s. North doesn't bother with Blackwood since he already knows about the Aces. He just bids the slam. North plays 6♦. East leads the ♥K, won by you with the ♥A.

The good news is that you have no losers in ♠s, ♥, or ♦s. The bad news is that you have two losers in ♣s. The good news is that missing the ♣ K Q you could try two finesses. The bad news is that East overcalled, so he probably has both honors. The best news of all is that you know how to pull off an elimination play!. Play a trump to dummy's ♦K (East discards a ♥) and ruff the ♥5.

Pull the outstanding trump with the ♦A, then play ♠A, ♠K and ruff a ♠.

You want to play the first ♣ from dummy.

You enter dummy with a trump.

Dummy leads the ♣10 and West plays low.

Play the ♣10 from dummy and let it ride if West does not produce the ♣Q or ♣K. East will win with one of the honors but will have to return another ♣ or give you a ruff-sluff.

When you are missing the K Q of a suit, as in the ♣s on this hand, taking two finesses gives you a 75% chance of success - **all things being equal**.

In this case though, East's overcall means all things are not equal, so your chances are lower than 75%.

But never mind the percentages for a finesse, the end-play was a sure thing.